

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · BEDTIME COMPANION

Ancient Troy

Wilusa in its letters and its layers

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

The hill of Hisarlik in north-western Turkey, near the Dardanelles. The Late Bronze Age city of Troy VI to VIIa (about 1750 to 1180 BCE), read beside the Hittite letters that name Wilusa; then Greek and Roman Ilion; then the people who dug the hill.

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Troy and the Dardanelles



Modern coastline and approximate site location (Natural Earth; UNESCO World Heritage List 849). Ancient shorelines differed from those shown here.

AT A GLANCE

- Hisarlik holds about ten cities, Troy 0 to Troy IX, each built on the ruins of the last over about four thousand years; this episode's city is Troy VI and VIIa.
- Troy VI (about 1750 to 1300 BCE) was a strong, wealthy citadel with a sloping limestone wall more than four metres thick, towers and gates; it most likely ended in an earthquake.
- Hittite texts name a western kingdom, Wilusa, most likely Troy; the treaty of Muwattalli II with Alaksandu (about 1280 BCE, CTH 76) is its clearest record.

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Places and remains in the episode

The hill of Hisarlik · Troy is the mound called Hisarlik, in Çanakkale province in north-western Turkey, near the Dardanelles. People lived on it for about four thousand years.

Size of the mound · When Schliemann first saw it, the mound was about 200 metres long, a little under 150 metres wide, and rose 31.2 metres above the plain.

Troy II ramps and palisade · The Troy II citadel was reached by two stone ramps, one still well preserved; its lower town had a wooden palisade nearly three metres wide.

The lost summit · Greek and Roman builders levelled the top of the hill, so the Bronze Age palace that probably stood there is gone.

The great wall of late Troy VI · The late Troy VI wall is of cut limestone blocks, over four metres thick, the stone part up to about nine metres high in places, topped with mudbrick.

Sloping outer face · The wall's outer face slopes strongly inward, while its inner face rises straight.

Sawtooth wall · The wall runs in sections of about 7-10 metres that meet at shallow angles, with small vertical offsets that seem decorative.

Solid ashlar · Unlike Mycenaean walls with a rubble core, Troy VI's wall is a solid mass of fitted blocks.

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CITIES THROUGH THE YEARS

The layers of Troy

Hisarlik holds about ten cities, Troy 0 to Troy IX, each built on the ruins of the last over about four thousand years; this episode's city is Troy VI and VIIa.

c. 3600-3500 BCE — An earlier layer, 'Troy 0', is known only from a few pottery sherds and wooden beams; its date is tentative.

c. 3000-2550 BCE — Troy I was founded around 3000 BCE on what was then the eastern shore of a shallow lagoon. Its citadel covered less than one hectare but had massive limestone walls.

c. 2550-2300 BCE — Troy II was twice the size of Troy I, with a lower town and a citadel of large megaron halls around a courtyard. Megaron IIA is the largest known building of its kind in the Aegean and Anatolia.

c. 2300-1750 BCE — The cities of Troy III to V were smaller and are poorly known, partly because Schliemann dug through them without recording them to reach Troy II.

c. 1750-950 BCE — Troy VI ran from about 1750 to 1300 BCE, Troy VIIa from about 1300 to 1180 BCE, and Troy VIIb from about 1180 to 950 BCE.

c. 1400 BCE — Wilusa first appears around 1400 BCE as 'Wilusiya', one of 22 lands of the Assuwa league that rose against the Hittite king Tudhaliya I/II and lost.

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The layers of Troy



c. 1300 BCE — Troy VIh fell around 1300 BCE: walls collapsed and ground subsided, most likely in an earthquake. The city was not burned.

1274 BCE — Wilusan soldiers may have fought in the Hittite army at the battle of Kadesh.

c. 1230-1180 BCE — Troy VIIa was destroyed in a fire, probably between about 1230 and 1180 BCE.

c. 950-700 BCE — After a fire around 950 BCE the hill was only thinly lived on until Greek settlers rebuilt from about 700 BCE.

c. 700 BCE-500 CE — Greek settlers rebuilt the city from about 700 BCE (Troy VIII); after 85 BCE it became Roman Ilium (Troy IX). Earthquakes around 500 CE devastated it.

1870 — In April 1870 Schliemann cut a great trench across the mound; he dug again in 1871-73, 1878-79, 1882 and 1890.

Dates are approximate. The episode distinguishes the archaeological layers from the later story of the Trojan War.

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Troy in the Aegean and Anatolia



A geographical reference map with modern coastlines. No disputed Bronze Age borders or conjectured siege routes are drawn.

People in the records

Alaksandu, king of Wilusa · Alaksandu, king of Wilusa, made a treaty with the Hittite great king Muwattalli II around 1280 BCE; it implies an earlier pact with Mursili II.

Muwattalli II, Hittite great king · Muwattalli II ruled the Hittites from about 1295 to 1272 BCE.

Kukkunni, king of Wilusa · King Kukkunni of Wilusa kept the peace with the Hittite king Suppiluliuma I while neighbours rebelled.

Piyamaradu, the western rebel · Piyamaradu was a western Anatolian rebel who troubled three Hittite kings for at least 35 years, often backed by Ahhiyawa. Piyamaradu married his daughter to Atpa, who ruled Millawanda (Miletus) for Ahhiyawa.

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People in the records

Queen Puduhepa · Queen Puduhepa, wife of Hattusili III, made a vow to the sea god for help in catching Piyamaradu.

Walmu, king of Wilusa · Walmu is known only from this letter; it does not say who deposed him.

The finders: Calvert, Schliemann, Dörpfeld, Blegen · Schliemann, disappointed at Pınarbaşı, was about to give up when Calvert pointed him to Hisarlik. The architect Wilhelm Dörpfeld, born in Barmen, joined Schliemann in 1882 and, after his death, dug Troy VI in 1893-94 for Sophia. Carl Blegen of the University of Cincinnati excavated Troy from 1932 to 1938 and divided the nine cities into 46 sub-phases.

Manfred Korfmann and C. Brian Rose · From 1988 to 2005 a Tübingen-Cincinnati team under Korfmann excavated Troy. C. Brian Rose led the Greek, Roman and Byzantine excavations at Troy from 1988 to 2012 and wrote The Archaeology of Greek and Roman Troy (2014).

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- Troy I left dark handmade pottery, copper objects and a stone stele carved with an armed figure. It ended in a fire around 2550 BCE.
- Wheel-made pottery appears for the first time in Troy II, and its treasures used Baltic amber, carnelian from India and lapis lazuli from Afghanistan.
- Of 98 pot shapes used in Troy VI, 90 were new, a sharp break from the Early Bronze Age tradition of Troy I-V.
- In front of a tower beside the main gate stood a row of four (perhaps once six) stone pillars, probably religious.
- Troy VIIa's pottery is almost the same as late Troy VI's, but it held fewer imported Mycenaean pots.

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT REMAINS UNCERTAIN

Hittite letters tell of the rebel Piyamaradu and a quarrel with Ahhiyawa, most likely Mycenaean Greeks, 'over Wilusa' that ended in peace. No text describes a siege.





AI-generated artistic impressions made for the episode, not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Hittite Diplomatic Texts ↗, Gary Beckman, edited by Harry A. Hoffner Jr., 2nd edition (Scholars Press, 1999). No. 13 is the Alaksandu treaty (CTH 76).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Archaeological Site of Troy — UNESCO Troy is the mound called Hisarlik, in Çanakkale province in north-western Turkey, near the Dardanelles. People lived on it for about four thousand years.

Alaksandu treaty fragment — British Museum Tablet 108569, from Boğazköy.

Troy VI — Dartmouth College J. B. Rutter, Aegean Prehistoric Archaeology, Lesson 23.

"The layers lie still, one above the other, and the hill holds every one of them."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

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